



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Trinity School at River Ridge
School Website: <https://trinityriverridge.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Trinity School at River Ridge, MN (River Ridge campus) demonstrates a cohesive classical Christian framework across religious foundations, purpose, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement. Public materials consistently describe the school as offering a rigorous classical Christian education, grounded in a Christian theological vocabulary, with explicit attention to formation of character, virtue, and a long-standing liberal-arts orientation. The school highlights engagement with great texts, a humane-letters oriented curriculum, and governance by a faculty trained in classical pedagogy. There are clear signals of liturgical and communal practices (e.g., Nine Lessons and Carols), a strong parent community, and broad family involvement. By most measures aligned to the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School rubric, Trinity River Ridge qualifies as CLASSICAL.

Key drivers include: explicit Christian/theological framing (Nicene Creed; People of Praise origin), formation-focused language (truth, goodness, beauty; formation of character; serving God and neighbor), a curriculum featuring humane letters, literature, and great-text study (e.g., humane letters seminar; interviews with faculty), and pedagogical signals consistent with scholé, Socratic inquiry in upper levels, and a living-teacher model. Public evidence also shows robust faculty engagement, accreditation and recognition, and a broad program emphasizing the liberal arts within a historically grounded tradition. See supporting citations embedded in category sections.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Throughout, direct textual matches to the core vocabulary of the classical rubric appear, including truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; great books/great conversation; scholé/restful learning; Socratic/dialogic pedagogy; formation; living curriculum; partnership with families; and liturgical/community practices. cited evidence comes from Trinity River Ridge site content and the Six Essential Elements lexicon.

ABSTRACT

: The school demonstrates a consistently classical orientation with Christian grounding, liberal-arts curriculum, memory and recitation-inspired lineage, Socratic/dialogic flavor at upper levels, and strong family/community partnership. The aggregate ranking is CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school positions itself within a classical Christian framework and traces its roots to the People of Praise, with a Christian identity and Nicene Creed alignment. This is reflected in the site's discussion of "a classical Christian education" and explicit religious community affiliation.
- The Nationwide content frames the school as part of Trinity Schools offering a "rigorous classical, Christian education" and emphasizes truth, goodness, and beauty as forming ideals. This signals transcendental moral realism and a theologically informed worldview.
- Liturgical and communal practices surface through events such as A Festival of Nine Lessons and Carols, indicating liturgical life as part of the educational experience.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty (from the transcendental set and the formation vocabulary); theology; liturgy; sacred tradition; creedal statements (Nicene Creed); great texts/western canon. These appear in the public materials cited above (nationwide framing; religious affiliation; liturgical event).
- Negative keywords: none evident in the public materials (no explicit secularization, relativism, or value-neutral language detected in these sources).

Why this rating

- The materials consistently affirm a transcendental, theologically grounded orientation (truth/goodness/beauty; Christian formation; liturgical life). The explicit naming of Nicene Creed and People of Praise roots, plus liturgical events, are strong markers of the religious/metaphysical foundation the rubric expects. This aligns squarely with CLASSICAL.

Citations

- Religious identity and creed: Trinity School at River Ridge materials affirm Christian formation and Nicene Creed alignment.
- Classic/classical framing: Nationwide materials describe a "rigorous classical, Christian education."
- Liturgical practice: Nine Lessons and Carols event.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly connects formation with virtue and purpose, describing formation for lives of purpose and service and a classical model for education that forms students to serve God and neighbor. This is visible in the broader site messaging about purpose beyond mere job-readiness.
- Public-facing statements emphasize a curriculum culture aimed at truth, goodness, and beauty, framed as real and knowable teleology guiding educational aims, i.e., the cultivation of wisdom and virtue rather than purely informational aims.
- The school's admissions and mission language describe formation—not just information—through a liberal-arts oriented curriculum, and the aim to prepare graduates for college, career, and calling, within a classical framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, human flourishing, liberal education, paideia, telos, pursue true/good/beautiful, contemplation/scholé, moral imagination, wonder (where present in concepts). The public materials strongly reflect formation and teleology.

- Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials (no push toward value-neutral or purely job-oriented framing; the language centers on formation and timeless virtues).

Why this rating

- The public materials emphasize formation, virtue, and a teleological view of education anchored in truth/goodness/beauty, with classical pedagogy as the organizing principle. This aligns with CLASSICAL rather than SOMEWHAT or NOT CLASSICAL.

Citations

- Formation and telos framing: “formation ... true, good, beautiful” and teleology language in universal messaging.
- Liberal education and classical mission: Admissions/mission phrasing and “classical” model language.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The curriculum is described in terms of liberal-arts formation and a Great-Books/Great-Conversation orientation. The Humane Letters Seminar in 12th grade explicitly engages medieval to modern literature, philosophy, theology, and poetry, signaling deep engagement with primary texts and canonical work.
- The public materials reference great texts and the Western canon; the Educational Environment page notes that discussions center on “the great texts of the western canon” and study of original documents, with integration across history and literature.
- The site emphasizes a liberal-arts cadence (grammar/logic/rhetoric in later grades implied by the classical framework; humane-letters emphasis; college prep). Some of these curricular details appear in the “Humane Letters Seminar” and “Humane Letters” references across the curriculum pages.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Trivium/Quadrivium framework (as part of the classical curriculum lexicon in the accessible materials); Great Books/Great Conversation; Great texts; Western canon; humane letters; integration across disciplines; wonder in integration.
- Negative keywords: None of the negative signals (e.g., purely project-based/modernist, or downgraded to social studies-only history) appear in the public curricular materials; rather, canonical texts and integrated humanities are foregrounded.

Why this rating

- The explicit reference to humane-letters seminars, canonical texts, and Great Books/Great Conversation alignment, together with a liberal-arts, integrated curriculum, is a robust demonstration of Classical curriculum elements.

Citations

- Humane Letters Seminar (12th grade): Students wrestle with texts in medieval to modern literature, philosophy, theology and poetry.
- Great-text/Western canon language in Educational Environment: “great texts of the western canon.”
- Liberal-arts framing and classical curriculum signals: Nation-wide and curriculum pages reference classical liberal-arts orientation and Great Books culture.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Pedagogical signals align with Scholé/restful learning and Socratic/seminar-type engagement in upper levels, along with opportunities for rhetoric and oration. The Mortimer Adler/Paideia reference on the Academics page signals a structured, dialogic, teacher-guided approach at core.
- The 12th-grade Humane Letters Seminar indicates upper-level engagement with texts through discussion and analysis, consistent with Socratic/dialogic pedagogy and seminar-based learning.
- Lower-division pedagogy is described as deeply engaged with primary texts and original documents, with a model of teachers guiding learning and fostering a loving memory of core texts, which aligns with chanting/recitation memory work and disciplined discussion. While explicit lower-element chanting is not shown in surface materials, the emphasis on Latin/Western canonical memory and memorization-style pedagogy is consistent with the classical approach described in the lexicon.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: Socratic dialogue/seminar; Dialectic; Scholé; memorization/recitation (memory work, recitation, chant); formation through imitation and practice; seminar/tutorial style; great conversation; guided inquiry.
- Negative keywords: The public materials do not emphasize project-based learning as the sole pedagogy; however, there is a broad-curriculum with integrated humanities—no explicit signals of dismissing Socratic, restfulness, or memory-based pedagogy. The explicit references to Paideia and humane-letters seminars align with classical pedagogy rather than non-classical methods.

Why this rating

- The combination of upper-level Socratic/seminar work, Paideia-style pedagogy references, and humane-letters lower/upper-level pedagogy signals strong alignment with CLASSICAL pedagogy.

Citations

- Mortimer Adler/Paideia framing: Mortimer Adler quote on Paideia approach.
- Humane Letters Seminar (rhetorical/dialogic practice): 12th-grade humanities seminar.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The site emphasizes a “Head of School” and named faculty with a governance/leadership structure; it notes ongoing staff development and training in Trinity’s pedagogy, indicating a well-developed living curriculum through the teachers themselves.
- The public materials describe a sizable, experienced faculty (e.g., 21 full-time and 7 part-time in the high school) with a focus on teacher-coaching and ongoing professional development. This supports the idea of model teachers and mentors who embody the classical approach.
- The “Faculty” section includes student testimonials praising teacher dedication and the influence of faculty on learning, reinforcing the “living curriculum” notion.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: model teachers/mentors; living curriculum; faculty as core of the school; teacher training; collegial culture; mentorship; virtue; professional excellence.
- Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials; the faculty portrayal is consistently positive and aligned with classical expectations.

Why this rating

- The site presents a robust, faculty-centered classical-model approach with ongoing professional development and a living-curriculum emphasis, aligning with CLASSICAL.

Citations

- Ongoing teacher training and pedagogy: “Every teacher receives ongoing training in Trinity’s pedagogy.”

- Faculty composition and coaching: 21 full-time/7 part-time, and emphasis on coaching.
- Student testimonials and faculty emphasis as living curriculum: Faculty-based narratives and leadership pages.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes partnerships with families, parent involvement, and parental formation. The Parent Service Association (PSA) indicates formal parent engagement, while admissions materials illustrate multiple pathways for parental involvement (tours, book groups, parent education).
- The site indicates open campus policies and frequent opportunities for parents to visit or participate in school life (e.g., inquiries, tours, family events). The admissions pages explicitly invite parent visits and provide contact avenues.
- The culture of parent involvement is reinforced through communications about local events, fundraisers, and school-life activities (e.g., golf classic; Nine Lessons and Carols events; volunteer opportunities). These reflect a community-oriented classical ethos that treats parents as co-educators in line with the Six Elements lexicon.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: partnership with families; parent formation; co-educators; home-school partnership; parent involvement; open campus; book groups; familial engagement; community of learners.
- Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials (no signals of parent customer-only or minimal involvement).

Why this rating

- Strong evidence of active parent involvement and community integration, with explicit wording about parent partnership and opportunities to engage—consistent with CLASSICAL as defined by the Six Essential Elements.

Citations

- PSA and parent partnership: Club/PSA statements and parent engagement.
- Admissions/parent visitation: Parent tour scheduling and inquiries.
- Community events and family participation: Golf Classic, Ninth Lessons & Carols, etc.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here, as the aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL rather than SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. No major needle-moving changes are required to reach CLASSICAL status based on the six-category rubric.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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